

Day 110 — TNPSC Group 2A Study Material

Part A – General Studies: Current Affairs in History & National Movement (10): Opening Monument Conservation to Private Agencies

READING MATERIAL

Covers a major 2026 policy shift: India's Ministry of Culture opening monument conservation to private agencies, ending ASI's exclusive control.

Q: What major policy change did India's Ministry of Culture announce regarding monument conservation in 2026?

A: Allowing PRIVATE conservation agencies to participate in restoring the country's protected monuments — ending the Archaeological Survey of India's (ASI) longstanding exclusive control over this work.

Q: How can corporate donors participate in monument conservation under this new approach?

A: Through Corporate Social Responsibility (CSR) contributions to the National Culture Fund — donors can choose from a list of 250 monuments urgently needing conservation, or approach the Ministry separately for monuments in specific regions.

Q: How many centrally protected monuments does the ASI currently safeguard, and what was conservation expenditure for 2024-25?

A: 3,686 centrally protected monuments; conservation expenditure for 2024-25 was ₹374 crores.

Q: What technologies are being integrated into India's monument conservation efforts?

A: LiDAR, GIS mapping, drones, 3D scanning, photogrammetry, and AI — used for documentation and diagnostics, including drone-based surveys conducted in collaboration with institutions like NISER (National Institute of Science Education and Research).

MOCK TEST (WITH ANSWERS)

1. India's Ministry of Culture's 2026 policy change on monument conservation primarily:

- A. Banned all private involvement
- B. Opened conservation work to private agencies, ending ASI's exclusive control ✓**
- C. Transferred all monuments to state governments
- D. Closed monuments to the public

Explanation: Opened conservation to private agencies, ending ASI's exclusive control. [medium, web-research]

2. Corporate donors can fund monument conservation via CSR contributions to which fund?

- A. Swachh Bharat Kosh
- B. PM CARES Fund
- C. National Culture Fund ✓**
- D. Heritage Conservation Trust

Explanation: National Culture Fund. [medium, web-research]

3. How many monuments are listed as urgently needing conservation, that corporate donors can choose from?

- A. 100
- B. 150
- C. 250 ✓**
- D. 350

Explanation: 250. [hard, web-research]

4. The ASI currently safeguards how many centrally protected monuments?

- A. 2,686
- B. 3,186
- C. 3,686 ✓**
- D. 4,186

Explanation: 3,686. [hard, web-research]

5. Conservation expenditure for India's protected monuments in 2024-25 was approximately:

- A. ₹174 crore

B. ₹274 crore

C. ₹374 crore ✓

D. ₹474 crore

Explanation: ₹374 crore. [hard, web-research]

Part B – Aptitude & Mental Ability: Visual Reasoning

READING MATERIAL

Visual Reasoning is 1 of 6 named Reasoning skills, testing image-based logic rather than text/number puzzles — mirror images, water images, and embedded figures are the standard formats. Note: TNPSC's own answer key has at least one acknowledged disputed mirror-image question, a useful reminder that on visual questions specifically, double-check your own reasoning rather than assuming the 'obvious' answer is automatically right.

Q: What is the rule for a MIRROR image, and what stays the same vs. flips?

A: A mirror image flips LEFT and RIGHT (the right side of the object appears on the left, and vice versa), while TOP and BOTTOM stay the same. Imagine holding the figure up to a vertical mirror.

Q: What is the rule for a WATER image, and how is it different from a mirror image?

A: A water image flips TOP and BOTTOM (it appears upside-down, as if reflected in still water below the object), while LEFT and RIGHT stay the same. This is the opposite axis of flipping compared to a mirror image.

Q: What is the best strategy for solving mirror/water image questions quickly?

A: Focus on the most unique or asymmetric part of the figure first (not the symmetric parts, which look the same either way) — mentally flip just that distinctive part along the correct axis (vertical line for mirror, horizontal line for water), and use it to eliminate options before checking the rest.

Q: What is an 'embedded figure' question, and what does it test?

A: A question where a simple shape is hidden within a more complex, cluttered figure, and you must identify which of the answer-choice shapes appears embedded within it. Tests visual scanning and pattern-matching rather than flipping/rotation.

Q: Real exam (flagged as disputed by TNPSC itself): A figure is shown, and you must choose its correct mirror image from 4 options.

What's the most reliable way to verify your choice, given that even the official answer key has had disputed cases here?

A: Don't just eyeball it — explicitly trace which side each distinctive feature should land on after a left-right flip, point by point, rather than relying on a quick visual impression. Given that TNPSC's own committee has had to review at least one mirror-image answer, treat your worked-through reasoning as more trustworthy than a snap visual judgment, and double-check rather than rushing.

MOCK TEST (WITH ANSWERS)

1. In a MIRROR image of a figure, which pair of sides swap?

- A. Top and bottom
- B. Left and right ✓**
- C. Diagonal corners only
- D. Nothing swaps

Explanation: Left and right swap; top and bottom stay the same. [easy, web-research]

2. In a WATER image of a figure, which pair of sides swap?

- A. Top and bottom ✓**
- B. Left and right
- C. Both pairs swap
- D. Neither swaps

Explanation: Top and bottom swap; left and right stay the same. [easy, web-research]

3. The letter 'b' would appear as which letter in its mirror image (left-right flip)?

- A. b
- B. d ✓**
- C. p
- D. q

Explanation: 'b' has its stem on the left with the bowl attached at bottom-right. Flipping left-right moves the stem to the right with the bowl at bottom-left — that's the letter 'd'. [medium, authored]

4. The letter 'b' would appear as which letter in its water image (top-bottom flip)?

- A. b
- B. d

C. p ✓

D. q

Explanation: Flipping 'b' top-to-bottom keeps the stem on the left but moves the bowl from bottom-right to top-right — that's the letter 'p'. (Mirror and water images of the same letter generally differ — here mirror gives 'd', water gives 'p'.) [hard, authored]

5. An 'embedded figure' question primarily tests:

A. Arithmetic ability

B. Visual scanning and pattern-matching within a cluttered figure ✓

C. Vocabulary

D. Memory of a list

Explanation: Visual scanning/pattern-matching to find a hidden shape within a complex figure. [medium, web-research]

Part C – General English: Poem: "The Secret of the Machines" — Rudyard Kipling

READING MATERIAL

A poem narrated FROM THE PERSPECTIVE of machines themselves, describing how they're made, what they need to run, their capabilities, and their fundamental limitation: they're powerful but lifeless without humans. Real coaching-site evidence tests figure-of-speech identification heavily.

Q: Who wrote "The Secret of the Machines", and what is its central message?

A: Rudyard Kipling. Central message: machines are spoken of in first person ('we'), describing their manufacture and impressive capabilities (working 24 hours, doing tasks humans do), but the poem's real 'secret' is that machines are entirely dependent on humans to create and direct them — without people, they are worthless. The poem argues we should use machines to empower ourselves, not become dependent on them.

Q: How does the poem describe the manufacturing of machines?

A: Raw materials (iron-ore, minerals) are taken from ore-beds and mines, melted in furnaces, then hammered and shaped into various designs, cut and measured to the required size and weight.

Q: What do the machines say they need to operate, and what are their capabilities?

A: Just water, coal, and oil. They can work 24 hours a day, and can perform tasks that replace or assist human work (reading, writing, counting, pulling, hauling, pushing, lifting, driving).

Q: What is the central LIMITATION of machines, per the poem?

A: They cannot feel emotions like humans — they can only obey commands, and can be dangerous if handled improperly. Ultimately, however capable, they remain mere creations of the human brain.

Q: Identify the figure of speech: "We were taken from the ore-bed and the mine, we were melted in the furnace and the pit."

A: Anaphora — repetition of 'we were' at the start of successive clauses.

Q: Identify the figure of speech: "Some water, coal, and oil is all we ask!"

A: Assonance — repetition of vowel sounds within the line.

Q: Identify the figure of speech: "We will serve you four and twenty hours a day!"

A: Hyperbole — an exaggerated, emphatic claim about constant availability.

Q: What is the rhyme scheme of the poem's stanzas (e.g. ask/play/task/day)?

A: ABAB.

MOCK TEST (WITH ANSWERS)

1. "The Secret of the Machines" was written by:

- A. Walter de la Mare
- B. Rudyard Kipling ✓**
- C. Robert Frost
- D. John Masefield

Explanation: Rudyard Kipling. [easy, web-research]

2. According to the poem, what is the central LIMITATION of machines?

- A. They break down too often
- B. They cannot feel emotions and merely obey commands ✓**
- C. They are too expensive to build
- D. They require constant supervision by experts

Explanation: They cannot feel emotions, only obey commands. [medium, web-research]

3. "We were taken from the ore-bed and the mine, we were melted in the furnace and the pit" uses which figure of speech?

- A. Apostrophe
- B. Anaphora ✓**
- C. Personification
- D. Metaphor

Explanation: Anaphora — repeated 'we were' structure. [medium, web-research]

4. "We will serve you four and twenty hours a day!" is an example of:

- A. Alliteration
- B. Repetition
- C. Hyperbole ✓**
- D. Personification

Explanation: Hyperbole. [medium, web-research]

5. What do the machines, in the poem, say they need to operate?

- A. Electricity and steel only
- B. Water, coal, and oil ✓**
- C. Sunlight and wind
- D. Human supervision only

Explanation: Water, coal, and oil. [easy, web-research]

6. The rhyme scheme of the poem's stanzas (e.g. ask/play/task/day) is:

- A. AABB
- B. ABBA
- C. ABAB ✓**
- D. No fixed rhyme

Explanation: ABAB. [medium, web-research]